

HERONS, STORKS AND FLAMINGOS



HERONS AND THEIR relatives are distinctive birds, with long, slender legs and a large beak. Most of them eat fish and other water animals, and can wade out into the water to look for food without getting their feathers wet. Herons hunt by stealth, and several species have developed remarkable fishing techniques. Flamingos catch their food by straining it through fibrous plates in their beak. Although storks have long legs, most of them do not wade, but catch their food on land. Many of these birds are sociable animals, living and nesting in large flocks or colonies. This gives them some protection from predators.



Cattle egret

This small heron lives near cattle and other grazers, and snaps up the small animals that they disturb. In recent years, cattle egret have become one of the world's most widespread birds.



Bittern

Bitterns live in dense reedbeds where they are perfectly camouflaged. When threatened, they point their beak skyward and sway gently. This makes them look like the reeds moving in the wind.



Neck is hunched at rest and in flight.

Herons often rest with one leg raised.

Adult goliath heron

Juvenile goliath heron

Long, straight legs

Hérons

There are about 60 species of heron. They live all over the world, except Antarctica and the far north. Most live close to water, and they often nest in groups. They usually build their nests out of sticks and reeds in a tree or bush.



Black heron fishing

The African black heron strides into the water and raises its wings like an umbrella. This casts a shadow on the surface, which probably helps the heron to see any fish swimming below.

Fishing

Many herons, including the goliath heron, catch fish by wading into the water and then keeping absolutely still with their necks hunched. When a fish swims near, the heron crouches down toward the surface, then suddenly stretches out its neck and stabs the fish with its beak. Other herons have developed different fishing techniques.



Flamingo skull

Flamingos

Many of the five species of flamingo live in shallow, salty lakes where little else survives. They feed with their head upside down, using their uniquely shaped beak to filter tiny animals and plants from the water.



Colonies

Flocks of flamingos can contain more than 2 million birds. They build mound-like nests with mud that they scrape up with their beaks.



Marabou stork

Storks

There are 19 species of stork. Some feed by wading into water, but others live in quite dry places. The giant African marabou stork is a scavenger. It feeds on already dead animals, in the same way as vultures, but it will also eat live prey, such as insects, fish, rats, and small birds.

This stork has one of the largest wingspans of all birds.

Long legs and toes



Nests

White storks migrate long distances and return to the same place in Europe every year to breed. They are traditionally encouraged to nest on houses because they are supposed to bring luck.



Green heron

This heron usually hunts at night when many small animals are active. It often perches, legs bent, on a low branch, ready to pounce on its prey.



Fishing with bait

The North American green heron throws small twigs or pellets into the water. It waits for fish to be attracted by this bait and catches them when they come within range.

GOLIATH HERON

SCIENTIFIC NAME	<i>Ardea goliath</i>
ORDER	Ciconiiformes
FAMILY	Ardeidae
DISTRIBUTION	Africa, Arabian peninsula, India
HABITAT	Coasts, lakes, rivers, marshy ground
DIET	Mainly fish
SIZE	Length: 150 cm (59 in)
LIFESPAN	About 25 years

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